tfscan: a Terraform misconfiguration scanner compared with Checkov

Raj Chhapariya. All figures below are generated from saved scan results by `eval/` and `report/generate_report.py`.

1. Question and method

Can a small static scanner for 12 AWS rules, which returns UNKNOWN instead of guessing when a value cannot be resolved, match Checkov on a hand-labelled set? Ground-truth labels were established by manual code review prior to running either scanner to eliminate label contamination from scanner outputs. The sets are 101 fixture resources written for this project, and 33 scored items on TerraGoat (AWS folder, pinned commit). Each fixture is scanned in its own directory, so one fixture cannot affect another. Results are keyed by full path and resource address. A mapped Checkov check that did not run on an item is counted as a miss, not as a pass.

2. Caveats

- The fixtures were written together with the scanner. High scores on them are weak evidence. TerraGoat is the independent set and is small (33 scored items).
- TerraGoat was built by Bridgecrew, the company behind Checkov.
- On S3-03 the tools answer different questions: Checkov CKV_AWS_19 passes a bucket with no encryption block, tfscan fails it as “no explicit choice in code”. The headline row leaves S3-03 out.
- SEC-01 maps only to CKV_AWS_41 (provider blocks). Checkov’s separate secrets scanner was not run, which lowers Checkov’s SEC-01 recall.
- Each timing is a single run.

3. Results

Rule	Items	tfscan P	tfscan R	tfscan F1	tfscan UNKNOWN	Checkov P	Checkov R	Checkov F1	Checkov no result
CT-01	6	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	25.0%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	0
EBS-01	7	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	22.2%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	2
IAM-01	8	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	20.0%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	0
KMS-01	7	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	22.2%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	2
RDS-01	7	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	22.2%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	2
RDS-02	7	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	22.2%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	2
S3-01	12	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	14.3%	90.0%	100.0%	0.947	2
S3-02	12	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	14.3%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	2
S3-03	12	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	21.4%	n/a	0.0%	n/a	1
SEC-01	9	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	18.2%	100.0%	40.0%	0.571	6
SG-01	9	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	18.2%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	0
SG-02	9	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	18.2%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	0
All 12	105	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	19.4%	97.7%	79.6%	0.878	19
All but S3-03	93	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	19.1%	97.7%	93.5%	0.956	18
Fixtures	72	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	25.0%	96.9%	86.1%	0.912	18
TerraGoat	33	100.0%	100.0%	1.000	3.0%	100.0%	66.7%	0.800	1

Table 1: Precision, recall, F1 against hand labels. UNKNOWN-labelled items are excluded from P and R.

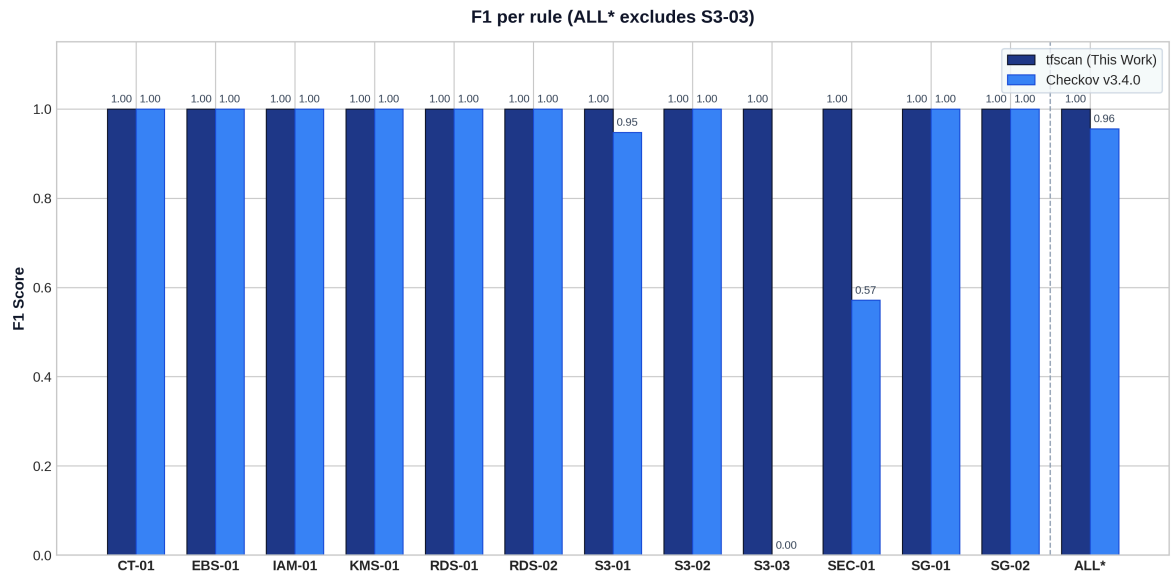


Figure 1: F1 per rule. ALL* excludes S3-03.

On the items with a definite label, tfscan scored precision 100.0% and recall 100.0%; Checkov scored 97.7% and 79.6% (all 12 rules). Without S3-03, Checkov recall is 93.5%. On TerraGoat alone tfscan scored 100.0% recall and Checkov 66.7%. Of 24 items labelled unknowable, tfscan answered UNKNOWN on 24; Checkov gave a definite FAIL or PASS on 9.

Timing (wall clock, includes process start-up): fixtures, tfscan CLI 180 ms against Checkov 5465 ms; TerraGoat AWS, 240 ms against 2533 ms. Much of the gap is start-up cost, so it should not be read as a per-resource speed ratio.

4. Disagreements

23 labelled items got different verdicts. tfscan matched the label on 13, Checkov on 1, and 9 were unknowable items. Per-item notes are in `docs/disagreement_notes.csv` and the README.

Item	Rule	Label	tfscan	Checkov	Right
Fi: case3_v4_pab_linked_by_name.tf	S3-01	PASS	PASS	FAIL	tfscan
Fi: case1_v3_no_sse.tf	S3-03	FAIL	FAIL	PASS	tfscan
Fi: case2_v4_no_sse.tf	S3-03	FAIL	FAIL	PASS	tfscan
Fi: case3_v4_unrelated_resource.tf	S3-03	FAIL	FAIL	PASS	tfscan
Fi: case2_module_kms.tf	S3-03	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case1_cidr_variable.tf	SG-01	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case2_port_variable.tf	SG-01	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case1_cidr_var.tf	SG-02	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case2_rule_remote_state.tf	SG-02	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case1_unresolved_multi_region.tf	CT-01	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case2_unresolved_validation.tf	CT-01	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case1_policy_variable.tf	IAM-01	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case2_template_file.tf	IAM-01	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	PASS	n/a (unknowable)
Fi: case2_db_literal_password.tf	SEC-01	FAIL	FAIL	NO_CHECK	tfscan
Fi: case3_resolved_default_password.tf	SEC-01	FAIL	FAIL	NO_CHECK	tfscan
Fi: case2_var_no_default.tf	SEC-01	PASS	PASS	NO_CHECK	tfscan
Te: s3.tf aws_s3_bucket.data	S3-03	FAIL	FAIL	PASS	tfscan
Te: s3.tf aws_s3_bucket.financials	S3-03	FAIL	FAIL	PASS	tfscan
Te: s3.tf aws_s3_bucket.operations	S3-03	FAIL	FAIL	PASS	tfscan
Te: s3.tf aws_s3_bucket.data_science	S3-03	FAIL	FAIL	PASS	tfscan
Te: s3.tf aws_s3_bucket.logs	S3-03	PASS	UNKNOWN	PASS	checkov
Te: ec2.tf aws_s3_bucket.flowbucket	S3-03	FAIL	FAIL	PASS	tfscan
Te: db-app.tf aws_db_instance.default	SEC-01	FAIL	FAIL	NO_CHECK	tfscan

Table 2: All disagreements. “Right” is blank-equivalent n/a for unknowable items.

5. Limits and what was fixed along the way

Evaluation exposed two scanner weaknesses, both found by checking disagreements against the code. The security-group rules asked for the CIDR before the port, so a rule on port 3306 with an unresolvable CIDR came back UNKNOWN; the port is now checked first. S3-03 returns UNKNOWN when an explicit encryption block has a KMS key given as a reference, which the labels treat as a pass; this is not fixed and is the one TerraGoat item where tfscan answered UNKNOWN against a PASS label. Static analysis of `.tf` files cannot see values set outside the code, which is why UNKNOWN exists.

6. Reproduce

`pip install -e .[dev]`, `bash scripts/fetch_terragoat.sh`, `python eval/run_scans.py`, `python -m eval.score`, `python -m eval.disagreements`, `python -m eval.plot_figure`, `python -m eval.generate_artifacts`, `python report/generate_report.py`. Environment: `results/ENVIRONMENT.md`.